

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

CFO-ORC FILE _____

NEW STATE RECORD _____

UNUSUAL RECORD X

7-0 (A)

Species: Mew Gull (*Larus [canus] brachyrhynchus*)

Red 1/20/00 wpl

Date: 1 January 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** ?**Plumage:** Def. Basic**Locality:** gravel pit pond, south of I-76, east of S. Platte R.**Elevation:** about 5000'**Nearest town:** Commerce City**County:** Adams**Time observed:** about 09:30 - 10:15 MST**Duration of observation:** off and on during that time period for a total of about 15 minutes

Description: While taking part in the Denver (Urban) CBC, I found an adult Mew Gull (MEGU) among Ring-bills (RBGU; about 20 in the immediate vicinity of the MEGU and >200 on the pond) on a gravel pit pond just south of I-76 on the east side of the S. Platte River that is accessed via the path along the river. The bird was already present when we approached the pond. It was swimming near the south end of the pond; all observers were at the north end of the pond. The light was fairly bad, but sustained watching produced fair views of all field marks discernible on a swimming gull.

The bird was a smallish gull, about 10% smaller than the nearby subadult and adult RBGUs. It had a white head with moderate streaking. In comparison to those of the RBGUs, the head was much rounder and somewhat smaller. The eyes were dark. The yellow bill, again in comparison to those of the RBGUs, was shorter and thinner, with virtually no gonydeal angle. The bird was partially backlit most of the time that we viewed it. Though this made seeing the precise bill pattern difficult, when the bird was sideways to us, light passed through the distal third of the bill (thus, appearing translucent). The bills of the nearby RBGUs never showed this phenomenon, instead, I could often discern the ring around the yellow bill of most similarly-positioned RBGUs. When I couldn't see the ring on individual RBGUs due to the backlighting, the bill looked wholly dark.

The neck was also white, again with moderate streaking, but with the nape having the densest streaking on the bird. The mantle and upper wing coverts were gray, somewhat darker than the similar tracts on the adjacent RBGUs. The difference in mantle color between the MEGU and the nearby RBGUs was about the same as shown between the gray of some other RBGUs on the pond and the two California Gulls (CAGU) near them. The scapulars were broadly tipped with white, forming a fairly wide, well-demarcated scapular crescent. The tertials were even more widely-tipped with white creating a very broad tertial crescent. These two crescents were very noticeable and were much larger and more well-defined than those of any of the RBGUs on the pond, or even than any RBGU that I have ever seen. The primaries were black, with large, white tips, with at least three primary tips extending beyond the tail tip. The underparts were white. I did not see the legs.

Similar species eliminated: Ring-billed Gull is eliminated by size, bill size and pattern, mantle color, head pattern, and scapular and tertial patterns. California Gull is ruled out by size and bill size and shape. Common Gull (*L.c. canus* and *L.c. heinei*) not definitively eliminated, but difference in mantle color between RBGU and Common is much less than between MEGU and RBGU. This would have made any difference difficult or impossible to detect due to the poor lighting conditions. Head and wingtip pattern (white tips) rule out both kittiwake species.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen many 100s of Mew Gulls, with the vast majority of those very recently (Dec. 1998 in northern CA and August and September 1999 in AK). I have seen uncountable bazillions of RBGUs. I have not seen any other form of what currently constitutes Mew [Common] Gull. I have seen 1000s of Black-legged Kittiwakes and no Red-legged Kittiwakes. I have also seen 1000s of CAGUs.

Light conditions: sun in front of, a bit to my right, and above me

Optical equipment used: Leica 32x

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest approach of about 150 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Dick Schottler, Dick Pratt, Bob Spencer, and Warren Finch

Other observers who saw the bird independently: none of which I am aware

If photographed, type of equipment and film: did not photograph

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature: 

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: Written on 10 and 17 January 2000 from notes written on the evening of 1 January 2000